# PSEUDOCOMPLETENESS OF COUNTABLE CLOSURES IN SPACES OF CONTINUOUS FUNCTIONS

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Abstract. We answer Question 4.8 of Dow and Tkachuk affirmatively in ZFC: if the closure of every countable subset of $C_p(X)$ is pseudocomplete, then the Tychonoff space $X$ is a $P$-space. More precisely, every non-$P$-space $X$ admits a closed separable metrizable linear subspace of $C_p(X)$ that is not pseudocomplete. The proof interpolates sequences at levels tending to zero: finitely supported sequences give continuous functions, whereas the constant sequence yields the discontinuous characteristic function of the complement of a non-open zero set. Coordinate evaluation helps make the interpolation image closed, and the Aarts–Lutzer characterization supplies the contradiction.

## 1. The result and the argument

All spaces considered below are Tychonoff. We give $C_p(X) = C(X, \mathbb{R})$ the topology inherited from $\mathbb{R}^X$, and write $\mathbb{N} = \{1, 2, \ldots\}$. A $P$-space is a space in which every countable intersection of open sets is open.

Dow and Tkachuk [2, Question 4.8] ask whether pseudocompleteness of the closure of every countable subset of $C_p(X)$ forces $X$ to be a $P$-space. Their Theorem 3.14 yields pseudocompleteness of $C_p(X)$ from this hypothesis; the conclusion about $X$ requires an additional argument. We prove the following stronger obstruction statement.

**Theorem 1.1.** *If $X$ is not a $P$-space, then $C_p(X)$ contains a closed separable metrizable linear subspace which is not pseudocomplete.*

**Corollary 1.2.** *If $\overline{A}^{C_p(X)}$ is pseudocomplete for every countable $A \subseteq C_p(X)$, then $X$ is a $P$-space.*

The key idea is to encode a sequence $a$ by a function satisfying $T(a)(x_n) = a_n$, using linear interpolation at levels $t_n \to 0$. Finite support makes the interpolant continuous at zero. In contrast, the constant sequence gives the characteristic function of $X \setminus Z$, which is discontinuous. Coordinate evaluation provides a continuous left inverse, and the interpolation image is closed. Pseudocompleteness would force the constant sequence into the same domain as the finitely supported sequences, yielding the contradiction.

## 2. The completeness obstruction

We use pseudocompleteness in Oxtoby's sense [4], as in [1, Section 2.1] and [2, Section 2]. A sequence $(\mathcal{B}_n)$ of $\pi$-bases witnesses pseudocompleteness if, whenever $U_n \in \mathcal{B}_n$ and $\overline{U_{n+1}} \subseteq U_n$ for every $n$, the intersection $\bigcap_{n\geq 1} U_n$ is nonempty. Here a $\pi$-base consists of nonempty open sets, and every nonempty open set contains one of its members.

**Lemma 2.1.** *A dense pseudocomplete additive subgroup of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$ is equal to $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$.*

*Proof.* Let $G$ be such a subgroup. By [1, Section 2.4, Corollary, p. 4], a metrizable pseudocomplete space contains a dense completely metrizable subspace; apply this to $G$ and take $D \subseteq G$ with this property. Since $D$ is dense in $G$ and $G$ is dense in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$, $D$ is dense in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$ as well. A completely metrizable subspace of a metrizable space is a $G_\delta$ subset of that space [3, Theorem 4.3.24]. Thus $D$ is a dense $G_\delta$ in the ambient product $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$, not merely in $G$. (For metrizable spaces, complete metrizability is equivalent to Čech-completeness [3, Theorem 4.3.26], so this agrees with the formulation of the characterization in [2, Section 2].)

Fix an arbitrary $a \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$. Translation is a homeomorphism of $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$, so $a + D$ is another dense $G_\delta$ subset. Since $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$ is completely metrizable, the Baire category theorem gives $D \cap (a + D) \neq \varnothing$. Hence $d_1 = a + d_2$ for some $d_1, d_2 \in D$, and $a = d_1 - d_2 \in G$. Since $a$ was arbitrary, $G = \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$. □

The same proof applies to a dense pseudocomplete subgroup of any completely metrizable topological group. Only the additive version above is needed here.

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## 3. The closed interpolation subspace

*Proof of Theorem 1.1.* A Tychonoff space is a $P$-space precisely when all its zero sets are open; a proof is recalled in Section 4. Choose a continuous $f : X \to [0,1]$ such that $Z = f^{-1}(\{0\})$ is not open. Positive values in $f(X)$ occur arbitrarily close to zero. Otherwise $Z = f^{-1}([0,\varepsilon))$ for some $\varepsilon > 0$, which would make $Z$ open.

Choose $x_n \in X$ so that, with $t_n = f(x_n)$,

$$0 < t_{n+1} < \frac{t_n}{2} \qquad (n \geq 1).$$

Then $t_n \to 0$ and the $x_n$ are distinct. No convergence of $(x_n)$ in $X$ is needed.

For $a = (a_n)_{n\in\mathbb{N}} \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$, we construct $u_a : [0,1] \to \mathbb{R}$ by linear interpolation between the prescribed values $u_a(t_n) = a_n$, setting $u_a(0) = 0$:

$$u_a(t) = \begin{cases} 0, & t = 0, \\ a_1, & t_1 \leq t \leq 1, \\ \dfrac{t - t_{n+1}}{t_n - t_{n+1}} a_n + \dfrac{t_n - t}{t_n - t_{n+1}} a_{n+1}, & t_{n+1} \leq t \leq t_n \quad (n \geq 1). \end{cases}$$

The pieces agree at their common endpoints and cover $(0,1]$; moreover, $u_a(t_n) = a_n$ for every $n$. The function $u_a$ is continuous on $(0,1]$.

For finitely supported $a$, the function $u_a$ vanishes on a neighborhood of zero and is therefore continuous on all of $[0,1]$.

Define

$$T : \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}} \to \mathbb{R}^X, \quad T(a) = u_a \circ f, \qquad P : \mathbb{R}^X \to \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}, \quad P(g) = (g(x_n))_{n\in\mathbb{N}}.$$

The map $T$ is linear. For each fixed $x \in X$, the $x$-coordinate of $T(a)$ is either zero or a fixed linear combination of at most two coordinates of $a$; hence $T$ is continuous for the product topologies. The evaluation map $P$ is continuous, and $P(T(a)) = a$. Thus $T$ is a homeomorphism onto its image, with inverse the restriction of $P$. Moreover,

$$L := T(\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}) = \{g \in \mathbb{R}^X : T(P(g)) = g\}$$

is closed in $\mathbb{R}^X$, since it is the equalizer of two continuous maps into a Hausdorff space.

Let $\mathbb{Q}^{(\mathbb{N})}$ denote the set of finitely supported rational sequences, and set $A = T(\mathbb{Q}^{(\mathbb{N})})$. This set is countable, and the finite-support property above gives $A \subseteq C_p(X)$. Since $\mathbb{Q}^{(\mathbb{N})}$ is dense in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$ and $T$ is a homeomorphism onto the closed subspace $L$,

$$\overline{A}^{\mathbb{R}^X} = L.$$

Because $C_p(X)$ has the subspace topology inherited from $\mathbb{R}^X$, it follows that

$$F := \overline{A}^{C_p(X)} = L \cap C_p(X).$$

Thus $F$ is closed in $C_p(X)$, separable (since $A$ is countable and dense in $F$), metrizable, and real-linear.

Put

$$G = \{a \in \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}} : T(a) \in C_p(X)\}.$$

Then $T|_G : G \to F$ is a homeomorphism, with inverse $P|_F$. Indeed, $P \circ T$ is the identity on $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$ and $T \circ P$ is the identity on $L$. The subspace $G$ is an additive subgroup containing $\mathbb{Q}^{(\mathbb{N})}$, so it is dense in $\mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$. Both $G$ and $F$ are metrizable.

Suppose $F$ were pseudocomplete. Then $G$ would also be pseudocomplete, and the lemma would give $G = \mathbb{R}^{\mathbb{N}}$. In particular, the constant sequence $\mathbf{1} = (1, 1, \ldots)$ would belong to $G$. By the interpolation construction,

$$T(\mathbf{1})(x) = \begin{cases} 0, & x \in Z, \\ 1, & x \notin Z. \end{cases}$$

Thus continuity of $T(\mathbf{1})$ would imply that

$$Z = T(\mathbf{1})^{-1}\big((-1/2, 1/2)\big)$$

is open, a contradiction. Consequently, $F$ is not pseudocomplete. □

*Proof of Corollary 1.2.* The set $A$ constructed above is countable and its closure in $C_p(X)$ is $F$. Hence the hypothesis rules out the obstruction in Theorem 1.1. □

## 4. Zero sets and scope

We recall the zero-set characterization used in the proof. Suppose every zero set in $X$ is open, and let $x \in \bigcap_{n\geq 1} U_n$, where the $U_n$ are open. Complete regularity supplies continuous functions $h_n : X \to [0,1]$ such that $h_n(x) = 0$ and $h_n = 1$ on $X \setminus U_n$. The series

$$h = \sum_{n\geq 1} 2^{-n} h_n$$

converges uniformly and defines a continuous real-valued function. Its terms are nonnegative, and any point outside some $U_n$ has a strictly positive $n$th term. Therefore

$$x \in h^{-1}(\{0\}) \subseteq \bigcap_{n\geq 1} U_n.$$

By assumption, this zero set is open. Thus every point of $\bigcap_{n\geq 1} U_n$ has an open neighborhood contained in the intersection, so the intersection is open. Conversely, every zero set is a $G_\delta$, proving the criterion. A real-valued zero-set function can be replaced by $|h|/(1+|h|)$ to obtain a function into $[0,1]$ with the same zero set.

Theorem 1.1 shows that whenever $X$ is not a $P$-space, a failure of pseudocompleteness can already be witnessed by a closed separable metrizable linear subspace of $C_p(X)$. The argument does not use inheritance of pseudocompleteness by arbitrary closed subspaces: in Corollary 1.2 the hypothesis is applied directly to the countable set $A$. Nor does the argument assume functional countability, or settle Question 4.9 of [2]. All constructions and completeness results used here are in ZFC.

## Disclosure of AI assistance

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## References

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